

“natives”—with British plants and European architecture. Once the Suez Canal opened in 1869, they had even less need for Indian women because British women could then travel to India much more easily.

Writers and freedom fighters

After the Mutiny, a “New Indian Woman” emerged, who challenged male and colonial superiority, and sought political equality. Poised between tradition and modernity, these privileged and educated women were writers and activists. Among their ranks were Cornelia Sorabji, the first female

graduate of Bombay University, and the first woman to study law at Oxford University and practice in Britain and India; Pandita Ramabai, a champion of women’s rights; and Sarojini Naidu, a poet, freedom fighter, and President of the Indian National Congress. Along with many others, these women actively participated in the cultural exchange between India and Britain after 1857, which outspokenly criticized both male and colonial dominance.



▲ Braveheart rebel

This postage stamp commemorates feisty female ruler Kittur Chennamma, who, sword in hand, led a rebellion against the British East India Company in 1824.



BIOGRAPHY

KHAIR-UN-NISSA

When British imperialist Colonel James Achilles Kirkpatrick stepped off the boat in Hyderabad, India, in 1795, he was eager to conquer the subcontinent. Yet, he found himself beguiled by Indo-Persian culture. He mingled with the local elite, where he met his future bride, 14-year-old Khair-un-Nissa, a wealthy noblewoman. Their union caused a scandal, but she bore him two children. Their story is the focus of William Dalrymple’s social history *White Mughals* (2002).